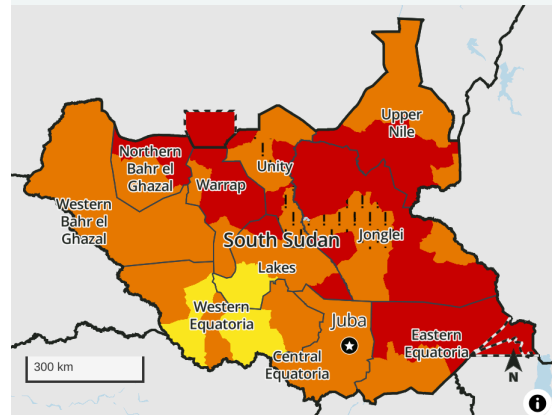


Fragile gains in assistance delivery amid lull in conflict, but risk of Famine persists

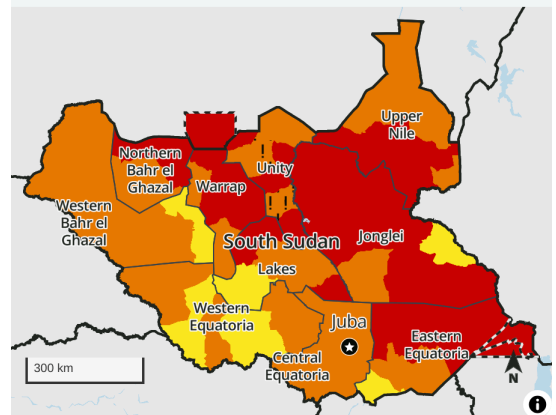
Key Messages

- Emergency (IPC Phase 4) outcomes are expanding during the lean season, likely reaching 34 counties across the north and northeast by September.** Deterioration is due to expected conflict- and flood-driven disruptions to household access to markets, assistance, and local food sources, and seasonally declining market supply amid rising costs. Acute malnutrition prevalence is expected to rise and surpass **Extremely Critical levels by June in 11 counties**. Violence has decimated health and nutrition service access, and widespread displacement has worsened disease spread (with rainy season exacerbations likely). Akobo, Nyirol, Uror, Fangak (Jonglei), Nasir, and Ulang (Upper Nile) remain areas of highest concern: populations with limited access to food and humanitarian assistance are expected to face Catastrophe (IPC Phase 5) through September.
- A credible risk of Famine (IPC Phase 5) persists in Akobo, Nyirol, Nasir, and Ulang.** Of particular concern are areas with ongoing or recent accessibility constraints (such as Chuil and **Nyatim** of Nyirol); areas at risk of renewed obstruction due to conflict and/or flooding; and areas hosting high numbers of internally displaced persons (IDPs). IDPs have often fled violence multiple times, lost income and food sources, and are most exposed to surging disease outbreaks in overcrowded conditions. If conflict escalates and isolates populations from food (including local sources and assistance) for a prolonged period, then Famine (IPC Phase 5) would likely occur.
- Amid persistent access constraints, humanitarians are scaling up the May-August lean season response in 26 counties, reaching at least 632,000 people (of the monthly target of 1.8 million) by mid-May.** In the counties at **risk of Famine (IPC Phase 5)**, distributions were underway in Nasir, Nyirol, and Akobo, and planned for June in Ulang. However, violence continues to undermine deliveries in Lankien (Nyirol), parts of Nasir, and Ulang. In **Akobo**, humanitarians are taking advantage of the **lull in conflict**, with **WFP** reportedly reaching more than 60,000 people with assistance; partners continue to conduct mass screenings of an estimated 1,000 children per day to identify and treat acute malnutrition. At least **36,000 South Sudanese** returned to Akobo from Gambela, Ethiopia, seeking assistance. Despite the scale up of assistance, there is a high risk of conflict disrupting delivery.
- Elsewhere in the 26 counties targeted for planned food and cash assistance responses,** May distributions were already underway in Fangak, Canal/Pigi, Ayod, and Uror (Jonglei), Greater Pibor Administrative Area

Projected area-level acute food insecurity outcomes, May 2026



Projected area-level acute food insecurity outcomes, June - September 2026



IPC 3.1 acute food insecurity classification

Sub-national level data

1: Minimal	3: Crisis	5: Famine
2: Stressed	4: Emergency	

Symbols

! Would likely be at least one phase worse without current or planned humanitarian food assistance

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners. For full disclosure, see endnotes.

Source: FEWS NET



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(GPAA), Longochuk (Upper Nile), and Panyijiar (Unity), while remaining counties were anticipated to receive the first distributions in late May or early June, according to recent plans. Insecurity and obstruction have disrupted distributions in Longochuk and Canal/Pigi. Overall, in May, food and cash assistance is expected to mitigate severity to Crisis! (IPC Phase 3!) in Duk, Uror, Leer, Rubkona, and Panyijiar.

- **Conflict remains the primary driver of severe food insecurity, disrupting humanitarian operations, markets, and crop and livestock production.** Clashes between the South Sudan People's Defense Forces (SSPDF) and SPLA-IO forces occurred in Longochuk and Nasir between **late April** and **early May**, resulting in displacement, civilian casualties, and disruption to humanitarian operations. Sporadic attacks involving SSPDF and SPLA-IO were also reported in **Torit** (Eastern Equatoria), disrupting first season crop production. Several incidents of retaliatory intercommunal conflict were reported in Greater Tonj (Warrap) and Duk and Twic East (Jonglei), resulting in over 100 deaths, displacement, livestock raids, and disruption to livelihood activities.
- **Internal and cross-border displacements remain volatile amid fluid conflict dynamics and as households seek access to limited assistance.** There were more than **300,000 IDPs** in Jonglei and Upper Nile between January 1 and May 7. With the lull in conflict and scale-up of assistance, nearly **79,000 previously displaced South Sudanese** returned from Ethiopia to parts of Jonglei and Upper Nile in May, including **5,000** to parts of eastern Nasir and 36,000 to Akobo. The daily inflow of returnees and refugees from Sudan remains **low and slowly declining** due to a combination of relative calm in some eastern areas of Sudan, engagement in the upcoming agricultural season, and increased conflict and deteriorating economy in South Sudan. Nonetheless, the elevated presence, at nearly **1.4 million** people, continues to strain resources and sustain high needs.
- **Following widespread early and above-average rain in March, atypically dry conditions prevailed through mid-May.** While **rainfall was cumulatively near average** for the first season in the southwestern bimodal areas, these late-season dry spells are affecting crop growth. In the unimodal north and northeast, the early rains encouraged localized early planting; However, field monitoring indicates poor germination and crop wilting by late April and May due to dry spells, likely to result in poor crop establishment and reduced yields.
- **South Sudan's macroeconomic conditions remain poor despite increased revenues from increased oil production and high global prices.** Crude oil production increased **16.3 percent** from January to May. Yet, the cash liquidity crisis persists amid ongoing fiscal mismanagement and lack of diversification, even as the government seeks to improve cash availability through **commercial banks** and increase **non-oil revenue streams**, such as via the **E-permit** system. The liquidity crisis and low inflows of foreign currency continue to drive depreciation, with the SSP value declining 6-17 percent year-on-year on the official and parallel markets.
- **The rising fuel prices in regional markets due to ongoing supply chain disruptions linked to the Middle East crisis are increasing supply costs and food prices.** Compared to February 2026 (when fuel prices first spiked), fuel prices in May were 45-105 percent higher in Aweil Centre, Juba, Rumbek Centre, Wau, and Bor South, and 50-90 percent higher than the same month last year. Increasing fuel prices are passing through to retail costs, exacerbating seasonal price increases as supplies decline. Based on price monitoring data, the retail prices of red sorghum per *malwa* (3.5 kilograms) in Wau, Rumbek Centre, Juba, and Aweil Centre were 8-50 percent higher in May than February due to increasing supply cost and household stock depletion.

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* FEWS NET classification is **IPC**-compatible with limited exceptions. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners. As of IPC 3.0, the IPC no longer assesses the impact of food assistance on classification and thus no longer maps the (!). However, FEWS NET continues to produce food security maps inclusive of the (!) as well as maps compatible with IPC 3.0/3.1, which include the mapping of food security assistance bags. In rare cases, FEWS NET classification is IPC-aligned but not IPC-compatible. IPC-aligned analysis is evidence-based but some types of evidence required for IPC-compatibility were not available.

Key Message Update

This Key Message Update provides a high-level analysis of current acute food insecurity conditions and any changes to FEWS NET's latest projection of acute food insecurity outcomes in the specified geography. Learn more [here](#).